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Promiscuous Ankles



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By Brian Weilert

As I stand in front of the full length mirror, looking at my image, the image of a blossoming 16 year old girl in a plain, pale dress, the gravity of the moment hits me three fold. One, I am looking in a mirror admiring myself, full of pride, a big no, no. Two, it is the first day of high school. And three, I can see my bare ankles. Why, you ask are any of these events cataclysmic? To answer this I must digress to events that led me to this moment. I'm Amish, or was Amish up until this summer. I might even still be Amish; I'm really just not quite sure. My father and I just moved; crazy times. I can tell you we were members of the Swartzentruber Amish, considered ultra conservative even by Amish standards. Where others could use electricity from time to time, we were not even allowed the use of battery lights. Our ordnung, or rules of our order, were so strict, I am pretty sure for every question you could think of, that started with, "Can you …..?" The answer would be, "NO!".

Anyway, my father did the unthinkable, he just up and quit. Of course, he didn't just up and quit, even though I just said it. Again, I should digress further.

Just over two years ago my mother passed away. I was devastated, still am. But, my up-bringing and beliefs allowed me to find comfort that seemed to elude my father. He just couldn't accept her death and he became angry. Angry at the others who tried to console him, but mainly he was angry at God. We were an odd family to begin with. First, there were just the three of us all along. Others had up to ten or eleven kids but not us. Mother said after me, she was unable to conceive anymore. I always felt a bit guilty, but not for hurting my mother but for being secretly happy that I was always going to be an only child. I am sure these thoughts were a sin. Secondly, we had no extended family in the order. My father joined when he was a young man, just after Vietnam; disillusioned with what the outside world, the Englishers, were doing with technology. "Pure evil" he would often say. It took many years for him to be accepted, but he finally was, and this is where he had been every since. But we were very happy. After her death, father tried to maintain his composure, just going through the motions; milking cows, farming crops while I took over all of mother's duties. Having just finished 8th grade, I was now finished with my formal education. Mother secretly had always wanted more for me. We would talk quietly, giggle filled whispers of a future we both knew was nothing more than a fantasy. The outside world didn't help. Thanks to the Supreme Court ruling in 1972 in Wisconsin V. Yoder, the elders now had the constitution on their side for not allowing me to further my education. Sometimes, I longed to be an Englisher. I think

my mother did too. But, my father was always so strict; neither of us would ever say a word. When mother took ill and all the old treatments didn't work, father finally rode horseback to a neighbor's, four miles in a blizzard to use a phone. He said since it was going to be a "conversation of purpose" he would be allowed to do so. But it was all too late. By the time a regular doctor got to see mother, the pneumonia had taken her life. That's when father started doubting it all. Like I said earlier, father played the part for nearly a year longer before it all fell apart. We have a word for when teenagers "sow their wild oats" know as *rumm-shpinga*, or run-around. Except, it wasn't a teenage *rumm-shpinga* but a middle-age-crisis *rumm-shpinga*. Father sold it all, saying everything on the farm reminded him of my mother, bought a car, a cell phone, a carton of Marlboros, packed our belongings and we left.

So, here I am in front of my mirror about to start high school after a two-year break from education. Unbelievably, my father now works at Radio Shack as a salesman; crazy times. I think he will eventually come to his senses, but for now this is how he is dealing with his grief and I'm okay with that. I know mother would be happy for me today. She would have stayed up all night making a special dress for the occasion. A dress I know would not expose my ankles. As I stare at them, bare, I am ashamed. I feel a bit dirty, but also sexy at the same time. I know this is insane but, I'm not my father. I thought I always wanted to be free from my life, but being Amish, is who I am. I know no other way. I feel as though I have two sides, a dark side that fantasizes of how I would drive the boys on the farm into a frenzy. I could just see them talking to me, but their eyes never making it above my knees, fixated on the sultry flesh, the round firmness of my ankle bones curving outward leading to the cleavage of where foot meets ankle. An innocent giggle and a slight twirl would raise the skirt to expose my lower calve. I can hear them breathing heavier as they stare, pretending to be interested in what I have to say.

The other side of me, the Swartzentruber side, wants to scold those same boys for their evil thoughts; for not recognizing me for my inner beauty and intellect. I would slap them for staring at my nude ankles and tear out the hem of the dress before sprinting home to bathe the filthy thoughts of those boys from my body.

Somewhere in between is the real me. I would get father's opinion but he has already left for work and the fact that he bought me a leather mini yesterday, is probably a solid hint as to which corner he would side with. I have no one to turn to for answers. The Amish me knows I should change clothes but the other one, the…the Englisher one wants so badly to let go; to fit in. I guess I'll turn to the only person I think will listen.

(praying) Mother, I need your help if God can spare you a moment. Crazy times down here. I bet you never thought father would go and turn into the anti-Amish. No, *666* hidden on his body but a Radio Shack name tag with *BILL* is bad enough. Crazy. Mom, I don't know who I am supposed to be. I know you wanted me to go to school so I'm okay with that, but I'm just not sure the person I am supposed to be when I get there. I'm looking for a sign to help guide me, or just a feeling that I'm heading the right direction. Can you do that for me? I would really appreciate it. *(pause, close eyes as if praying*

real hard) Okay, I get it. My decision. *(looks at clock)* Bus is going to be here in just a few minutes. I think I like the dress. I'll just keep and eye out on those boys at school and make sure they aren't sneaking any peaks. Plus, what they think won't change who I am inside anyway. Whoever that is when I get it figured out. Crazy. Thanks Mom and put in a word for father, will you? I love you. Amen.

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111 N Eddy
Fort Scott, KS 66701
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